



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRAICAIN DES ETUDIANTS
UNIÃO DOS ESTUDANTES DE TODA A ÁFRICA
اتحاد طلاب عموم إفريقيا



Tree Planting Exercise at Ghanata Senior High School



Headquarters, Accra Ghana
8 Finch Street Accra Ghana

✉ info@aasuonline.org / secgen@aasuonline.org



www.aasuonline.org



+233 302 547 128



+233 242 879 028 / +23350 267 2146

Foreword by the AASU Secretary-General

Climate change continues to pose an existential threat to our planet, with its devastating impacts increasingly felt across the African continent; from prolonged droughts and rising sea levels to erratic rainfall patterns disrupting agriculture and livelihoods. As these effects intensify, the urgency to act has never been greater. It is imperative that we, as young people and future leaders, take bold steps to mitigate these impacts and champion sustainability.

In line with this commitment, the All-Africa Students Union (AASU), through its Environment and Climate Action Working Group, in collaboration with Oxfam, organized a tree planting and environmental advocacy activity as part of our broader agenda to foster climate resilience and ecological stewardship among young people. This year's exercise was held at Ghanata Senior High School in Dodowa, a school carefully selected for its commitment and capacity to nurture and sustain the growth of the trees planted.

What makes this year's initiative particularly remarkable is our intentional investment in longevity and ownership. All planting materials, including cutlasses, hoes, watering cans, gloves, and black soil were donated to the school to empower them to continue the effort beyond the initial planting. Additionally, a targeted advocacy session was undertaken to educate and inspire students to become proactive stewards of their environment.

This report outlines the proceedings of this impactful exercise, which reflects AASU's unwavering dedication to environmental justice and intergenerational responsibility. We remain committed to mobilizing Africa's youth to lead the charge for a greener, more resilient continent.



Peter Kwasi Kodjie
Secretary General
All-Africa Students Union



2.0 Introduction

In line with its objective to promote environmental consciousness among African youth, the All-Africa Students Union (AASU), through its Environment and Climate Action Working Group, annually organizes a tree planting exercise as part of its climate action agenda. This year's event took place on 26th June 2025 at Ghanata Senior High School in Dodowa, Ghana.

The school-based outreach was designed as a comprehensive engagement that included a donation of essential planting tools, an educational advocacy session on climate change and sustainability, and a hands-on tree planting exercise involving enthusiastic participation from students, teachers, and school administrators. The decision to host the activity at Ghanata Senior High School was guided by the school's capacity and willingness to maintain and nurture the planted trees, ensuring long-term environmental impact.

This year's exercise aimed not only to increase green cover but also to intensify climate and environmental education within academic institutions. By engaging students directly, the initiative sought to open their minds to the prospects of pursuing education and careers in sustainability, and to inspire them to take ownership of climate solutions within their communities.

Tree planting remains one of the most effective natural solutions to combat climate change. Trees absorb carbon dioxide (CO₂), the most prevalent greenhouse gas, through the process of photosynthesis. According to the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO), one mature tree can absorb up to 22 kilograms of CO₂ per year, while one hectare of forest can store up to 250 metric tons of carbon. As such, reforestation and afforestation efforts play a crucial role in mitigating global warming and enhancing climate resilience.

Through this initiative, AASU reaffirms its commitment to empowering Africa's youth to lead on environmental action; one tree, one school, and one generation at a time



3.0 Activities

3.1 Donations

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) delegation arrived at Ghanata Senior High School at exactly 2:00 PM, where they were warmly received by the Headmistress, Assistant Headmistress, and other members of the school's administrative team. The atmosphere was one of anticipation and excitement, as students and staff gathered to welcome the team and participate in the day's green activities.



As part of its unwavering commitment to promoting environmental sustainability and climate action in educational institutions, AASU made a formal donation of tree planting tools and fruit tree seedlings to the school. This gesture was not only symbolic but also practical, as it provided the necessary resources to ensure the successful planting and ongoing care of the trees. The items donated included:

- **One digger** – for breaking ground and creating planting holes suitable for deep-rooted seedlings.
- **Watering cans** – essential for ensuring consistent and adequate watering, particularly during the early stages of tree growth.
- **Cutlasses** – to help clear underbrush and prepare the ground for planting.
- **Hand gloves** – to promote hygiene and safety during planting activities, especially for the students.
- **Seedlings of lemon, orange, and tangerine trees** – chosen not only for their environmental value but also for their long-term nutritional and economic benefits to the school community.

These tools were carefully selected to empower the school to maintain the trees independently and to integrate green practices into their routine activities. By providing durable and easy-to-use equipment, AASU ensures that the trees planted are not a one-day initiative but part of a sustained environmental stewardship program.

Following the donation, a brief presentation ceremony and photo session took place, capturing the momentous occasion and marking the beginning of a collaborative relationship between AASU and Ghanata Senior High School. The school leadership expressed heartfelt appreciation for the support and reiterated their commitment to nurturing the trees and integrating environmental education into their school culture.

This donation represents more than just tools and seedlings; it symbolizes an investment in the future of Africa's youth and the natural environment. It reinforces the idea that with the right resources, young people can be at the forefront of the continent's climate resilience efforts.



3.2 Advocacy Session

3.2.1 Overview

Following the donation of planting tools and seedlings, students were gathered in the school's assembly hall for an engaging advocacy session on climate change and environmental sustainability. The session formed a central part of the day's activities, designed to equip students with both knowledge and inspiration to become active environmental stewards.





The session was facilitated by the Chief Technical Officer (CTO) of AASU, Mr. Bismark Amefianu Koduofor, who delivered an interactive and thought-provoking presentation. He emphasized the urgency of climate action, linking it to real-life environmental challenges such as droughts, irregular rainfall, food insecurity, and rising sea levels; issues that are already impacting many parts of the African continent.

Mr. Koduofor challenged students to view climate change not as a distant issue but as a present and urgent reality that requires immediate attention. He highlighted the role of young people in championing environmental sustainability, calling on them to see themselves as changemakers in their schools and communities.

More importantly, the CTO encouraged students to explore academic and career pathways in climate science, sustainability, and environmental policy, emphasizing that environmental advocacy is not only a civic duty but also a strategic opportunity for future leadership and employment. He introduced students to real-world examples of how sustainability is transforming global economies and stressed the need for African youth to be part of that transformation.

The session was highly interactive, with students actively participating through questions, reflections, and open discussion. The exchange helped demystify climate issues and created a sense of ownership among the students.

3.2.2 Action Points

- Facilitation of a climate advocacy session by AASU's Chief Technical Officer, Mr. Bismark Amefianu Koduofor, tailored to over 300 students.
- Delivery of an impactful address linking local environmental concerns to global climate change and outlining youth roles in sustainability.
- Interactive dialogue with students, fostering curiosity and critical thinking around environmental action and sustainable development.
- Encouragement for students to pursue studies and careers in climate-related fields to build the next generation of environmental leaders.
- Commitment from school authorities to support and embed environmental education in the school's activities and culture.

This advocacy session was not merely a presentation but a capacity-building experience, aimed at nurturing a generation of environmentally conscious leaders prepared to champion Africa's green future.

3.3 Tree Planting Session

The program concluded with a practical and symbolic tree planting exercise, marking the final and most hands-on segment of the day's activities. This closing session brought together members of the AASU delegation, agriculture students and their teacher, as well as the school's leadership, in a collective act of environmental responsibility and climate commitment.



A variety of tree seedlings, including citrus species such as lemon and orange, as well as ornamental and shade-providing trees, were carefully planted at selected spots across the school compound. The inclusion of both fruit-bearing and ornamental species was intentional and designed to offer environmental, aesthetic, and potential educational value over time.

Using the tools donated earlier in the day that is; cutlasses, watering cans, a digger, gloves, and black soil the students, guided by their agriculture teacher and AASU's technical team, applied basic but essential tree planting techniques. These included spacing, pit preparation, soil handling, and watering procedures, all contributing to improved survival and growth of the trees.

The atmosphere was vibrant and collaborative, with students demonstrating both enthusiasm and care. Their participation reflected an eagerness to take ownership of the trees and a genuine interest in contributing to climate action efforts in their own school.

This final exercise symbolized more than just planting trees but it represented the cultivation of long-term environmental consciousness. It reinforced key messages from the earlier advocacy session and gave students a tangible way to act on what they had learned. The planting also set the foundation for a lasting relationship between AASU and Ghanata Senior High School, anchored in environmental stewardship, student empowerment, and a shared commitment to sustainability.

4.0 Key Takeaways

1. **Youth Engagement Is Crucial for Climate Action:** The interactive advocacy session demonstrated that students are eager to learn about climate change and are willing to take ownership of environmental issues when properly engaged and empowered.
2. **Schools Are Strategic Hubs for Environmental Stewardship:** Ghanata Senior High School's capacity and willingness to nurture and maintain the trees underscore the importance of selecting committed institutions for such initiatives.
3. **Hands-On Activities Strengthen Learning and Ownership:** The combination of tool donation, tree planting, and an educational session fostered a holistic learning experience that reinforced both the practical and theoretical aspects of environmental sustainability.
4. **The Right Tools Enable Long-Term Impact:** Providing essential and durable materials like cutlasses, gloves, and watering cans ensured that the tree planting exercise could be sustained by the school beyond the day of the event.
5. **Climate Advocacy Must Link Global Issues to Local Realities:** The facilitator's ability to connect climate change to everyday challenges in Africa (e.g., food insecurity, irregular rainfall) made the issue more relatable and actionable for students.
6. **Sustainability Can Be a Viable Career Path:** Introducing sustainability as a future academic and professional pursuit sparked curiosity among students and positioned environmental action as both a responsibility and an opportunity.
7. **Partnerships Amplify Impact:** Collaboration between AASU, Oxfam, and local school authorities strengthened the reach and effectiveness of the program.

5.0 Recommendations

1. **Select Schools with Strong Follow-Up Capacity:** Prioritize institutions that show a commitment to environmental education and the ability to maintain planted trees and integrate green practices into school routines.
2. **Incorporate Monitoring & Evaluation Mechanisms:** Establish a follow-up structure to track tree survival rates, student-led activities, and institutional changes inspired by the program.
3. **Expand Curriculum Integration:** Work with school authorities to embed sustainability topics into regular classroom learning and extracurricular activities.
4. **Link Students to Broader Climate Movements:** Connect participating students to national or continental youth climate networks to help them scale their engagement beyond the school.
5. **Broaden the Toolkit:** In future donations, consider including educational materials (e.g., climate action booklets, posters) and simple biodiversity monitoring kits to deepen environmental literacy.
6. **Strengthen Gender Inclusion in Environmental Advocacy:** Ensure both girls and boys are equally engaged and represented in all stages of the initiative to foster inclusive climate leadership.
7. **Scale to More Schools Regionally:** Replicate the initiative in other schools across different regions to create a wider network of climate-conscious youth leaders and tree-growing institutions.
8. **Document and Share Success Stories:** Use photos, testimonials, and impact reports to share the results publicly, which will inspire others and attract future partners and supporters.

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 aasu_1972

 @aasu_72

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 www.aasuonline.org

 info@asuonline.org